



OFF-SIDE

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IPL'S ADDICTION TO SURROGATE ADS IS UNDERMINING ITS FAMILY IMAGE

The IPL's **implicit endorsement** of liquor and tobacco brands normalises harmful behaviours, undermining years of public health efforts and significant financial investments.

Since it began in 2008, the Indian Premier League (IPL) has positioned itself as the nation's favourite family-friendly spectacle – a happy collusion of cricketing heroes and Bollywood glitter. Conveniently timed during India's annual academic break, it offered the youth, suddenly liberated from the tyranny of textbooks and tuition, something far more compelling than the melodramatic soap operas that usually dominate Indian drawing rooms for the rest of the year. Conversations with parents, mercifully, shifted from marriage proposals and board exams to M. S. Dhoni's helicopter shots and Virat Kohli's latest century.

But for all its family-friendly charm, television coverage of the IPL has slowly been overrun by surrogate advertising of liquor and tobacco brands. **Pan masala ads masquerading as promotions of "mouth fresheners" are now a regular feature of every IPL broadcast.** According to *TAM Sport*, a unit of TAM Media Research, which measures India's television audience, mouth fresheners accounted for 13 per cent of all IPL advertising in the first 40 matches of this season — more than anything else.

Ahead of the start of this year's tournament, the Director General of Health Services (DGHS) Prof. (Dr) Atul Goel, in a letter to the IPL chairman, had stated: "IPL should strictly implement the regulations banning all forms of tobacco/alcohol advertising, including surrogate advertisements, within the stadium premises where the games and related IPL events are held, as well as during telecast sessions on national television."

And the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI),

according to Agenda 9 of its Apex Council meeting, held a "discussion regarding sponsorship from tobacco and crypto brands" on March 22, the opening day of this year's IPL. However, the volume of mouth freshener commercials has increased from last year's share of 11 per cent.

Bollywood, of course, is also part of this problem. Superstars like Shah Rukh Khan, Ajay Devgn, and Salman Khan, flashing perfect teeth, peddle these brands. As adored public figures, their presence legitimises harmful habits among impressionable youth, packaging unhealthy products in glossy glamour and charm. Cricketers — retired and revered — have taken to the same business with the same selective amnesia, forgetful of the harm chewing pan masala can do to your insides.

The IPL, with its reach and influence, wields considerable power in shaping public attitudes. But when it implicitly endorses these brands, it normalises behaviours that public health campaigns spend crores and years trying to eliminate.

The financial incentives from these partnerships are substantial — pan masala brands, according to reports, had spent upwards of Rs. 350 crore during IPL 2024. And for a broadcaster trying to recover its Rs. 104-crore-a-match investment, the lure might be too significant to ignore.

But there must be other ways for the league to generate revenue without contradicting its values. It's disappointing to witness such a blatant commercial trade-off, one that risks tarnishing the IPL's reputation far more than any short-term gain can justify.